

CUES & AP QUESTIONS

NOTES

Why were the Americas isolated from the Old World?

What 3 things were ABSENT from the Americas before 1492?

Name the 3 major civilizations or cultures in Ch. 5.

AP EXAM TIP

CRITICAL: Americas in Unit 1 developed **INDEPENDENTLY** of Old World contact. **Never use Mongols, Black Death, Indian Ocean trade, or Islam to explain Aztec or Inca developments. They had no knowledge of each other.**

What is the AP significance of the Americas' isolation?

COMMON MISTAKE

The Americas were NOT primitive or less advanced than Old World civilizations. Tenochtitlan (Aztec capital) was larger than any European city in 1500. The Inca road network was longer than Rome's. Judge complexity on its own terms.

What happened when isolation ended in 1492?

WHY THE AMERICAS WERE ISOLATED

- › The Americas were separated from the Old World by the Atlantic and Pacific Oceans
- › The last land bridge (Bering land bridge) closed c. 10,000 BCE as ice sheets melted — ending the migration that had populated the Americas
- › No regular contact with Africa, Europe, or Asia until Columbus's voyages (1492) and Vasco da Gama's route to India (1498)
- › **Result:** The Americas developed complex civilizations entirely independently — different crops, animals, technologies, religions, and political forms

WHAT THE AMERICAS LACKED (And Why It Mattered)

- › **Large domesticable animals:** No horses, cattle, or oxen for farming/warfare. Llamas/alpacas in Andes; no equivalent in Mesoamerica. This limited agricultural productivity and military power compared to Old World
- › **The wheel (for transport):** Known conceptually (used in toys) but not applied to carts/wagons — no large draft animals to pull them
- › **Iron and steel:** Americas had bronze (Inca) and obsidian tools; no iron technology
- › **Old World diseases:** No exposure to smallpox, measles, influenza — populations had no immunity. This is WHY the Columbian Exchange diseases were catastrophic after 1492

THREE MAJOR CIVILIZATIONS IN CH. 5

- › **Aztec (Mexico) Empire** — Mesoamerica (central Mexico); founded Tenochtitlan 1325; empire built 1428–1519
- › **Inca Empire** — Andes (western South America); expanded rapidly under Pachacuti from 1438; largest pre-Columbian empire
- › **Mississippian Culture / Cahokia** — North America (Mississippi River valley); complex chiefdom; Cahokia peaked c. 1100 CE

WHY ISOLATION MATTERS FOR AP ESSAYS

The Americas' isolation means their political, religious, and technological achievements are entirely indigenous. They developed agriculture (maize, potatoes, tomatoes), monumental architecture, complex writing systems (Maya), calendar systems, and large empires **WITHOUT** contact with the Old World. This makes them a powerful counter-example to any argument that complexity requires cross-cultural contact.

AP TIP: When the Americas appear in AP essays, always note their isolation — then use it to argue that complex state-building, trade networks, and religion develop independently across human societies, not just in Eurasia.

SUMMARY — Write the main idea of this page in your own words:

The Americas developed complex civilizations in **complete isolation** from the Old World. Lacked: large draft animals, iron, wheel (for transport), and immunity to Old World diseases. Three major cultures: **Aztec** (Mesoamerica), **Inca** (Andes), **Mississippian/Cahokia** (North America). AP key: their achievements prove that complex state-building, monumental architecture, and trade networks emerge independently across human societies.

CUES & AP QUESTIONS

NOTES

Aztec / Mexica:

Where did they originate? When did they found Tenochtitlan?

Triple Alliance

What was it? How did it expand Aztec power?

Tribute system:

How did it work? What moved from conquered peoples to Tenochtitlan?

AP EXAM TIP

Aztec tribute system = AP's best Americas example for economic extraction and political hierarchy. Compare it to the Chinese tribute system — both involve subordinate states sending goods to a center, but with very different cultural frameworks.

Why was Tenochtitlan remarkable?

COMMON MISTAKE

The Aztec Empire was NOT monolithic — it ruled through tribute extraction, NOT direct administration. Conquered peoples maintained local rulers and cultures; they just paid tribute to Tenochtitlan.

What was the role of human sacrifice? How should it be contextualized for AP essays?

AZTEC ORIGINS AND THE FOUNDING OF TENOCHTITLAN (1325)

The **Mexica** (later called Aztecs) were a migrant people who arrived in the Valley of Mexico from the north c. 1200s. According to their own traditions, they were guided by their sun god **Huitzilopochtli** to found a city where they saw an eagle on a cactus eating a snake — **Tenochtitlan** (1325, modern Mexico City). Built on an island in Lake Texcoco, connected to shore by causeways.

THE TRIPLE ALLIANCE AND EMPIRE BUILDING

- › In 1428, the Mexica formed the **Triple Alliance** with Texcoco and Tlacopan — three city-states that together conquered the Valley of Mexico and beyond
- › By 1500, the Aztec Empire controlled ~5–6 million people across Mesoamerica
- › Empire built through military conquest followed by tribute extraction — NOT direct rule
- › Conquered city-states kept their rulers; had to pay tribute in goods and captives

THE TRIBUTE SYSTEM

- › Conquered peoples sent: luxury goods (cacao, jade, feathers, cotton textiles), food (maize), and **war captives for sacrifice**
- › Tribute flowed into Tenochtitlan, making it a center of redistribution and royal wealth
- › The system was extractive — conquered peoples often resented it (which is why Spanish conquistadors found willing allies among them in 1519)
- › **AP comparison:** Aztec tribute system vs. Chinese tribute system — both involve subordinate states sending goods to the center; but Chinese system was diplomatic/voluntary, Aztec system was military/coercive

TENOCHTITLAN — A World-Class City

- › Population c. 200,000–300,000 by 1500 — larger than any European city at the time
- › Built on an island with sophisticated chinampas (floating gardens) for agriculture
- › Causeways, aqueducts, marketplaces — sophisticated urban infrastructure
- › The **Great Temple (Templo Mayor)**: Twin pyramids dedicated to Huitzilopochtli (sun/war) and Tlaloc (rain) — at the center of the city and the cosmos

HUMAN SACRIFICE — Contextualizing for AP

- › Central to Aztec religious practice: belief that the sun required human blood to continue rising
- › Thousands sacrificed annually at Templo Mayor; war captives were primary victims
- › **AP analysis:** Do not exoticize or moralize — contextualize. Human sacrifice served political functions (demonstrating power over conquered peoples) and religious ones (maintaining cosmic order). Assess it within Aztec belief systems.
- › Resentment among conquered peoples over tribute and sacrifice made Spanish alliance possible

AP TIP: Tenochtitlan's size and sophistication is the single most powerful counter-argument to any claim that the Americas were 'less advanced.' Use it whenever AP essays make comparative claims about urban development.

SUMMARY — Write the main idea of this page in your own words:

Aztec (Mexico) Empire = tribute-extraction state built by the **Triple Alliance** (1428). Conquered peoples paid tribute in goods and captives; did NOT assimilate. **Tenochtitlan** (pop. 200,000+) was larger than any European city. **Human sacrifice** was central to maintaining cosmic order (in Aztec belief) and demonstrating political dominance. The tribute system = AP's best Americas comparison for economic extraction and political hierarchy.

CUES & AP QUESTIONS

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Inca Empire:

Where? When founded? Who expanded it rapidly?

Mit'a system

What was it? How was it different from tribute?

Quipu

What was it? What does it reveal about Inca governance?

AP EXAM TIP

Inca mit'a system = AP's best example of labor-based taxation (vs. goods-based tribute). Compare it to European serfdom, Egyptian corvee labor, or the Aztec tribute system. All are state-organized labor extraction methods.

How did the Inca road network function? Why does it matter for AP essays?

COMMON MISTAKE

The Inca had NO writing system — administration used quipu (knotted cords). Do NOT say 'Inca had no records.' Quipu recorded numerical and possibly narrative data — a sophisticated information management system.

How did the Inca use religion to legitimate political authority?

INCA EMPIRE — TAWANTINSUYU ('The Four Quarters')

The Inca Empire was centered at **Cusco** (Peru), founded c. 1200s but expanded dramatically under **Pachacuti** ('World Shaker,' r. 1438–1471). At its peak, the empire stretched ~2,500 miles along the Andes from modern Colombia to Chile — the largest pre-Columbian empire in the Americas.

THE MIT'A SYSTEM — Labor Taxation

- › The Inca taxed subjects through **labor**, not goods — every household owed the state a period of labor service (mit'a)
- › Mit'a labor built: roads, temples, terraced agriculture (andenes), and the city of Machu Picchu
- › In exchange, the state provided: food, tools, clothing, and protection during service
- › Mit'a applied to: men for military service and construction; women for weaving (akllakuna — 'chosen women' produced textiles for state redistribution)
- › **AP comparison:** Mit'a = labor tax (like Egyptian corvee); Aztec tribute = goods tax; European feudal obligations = labor + military service. All are state-extraction systems with different forms

QUIPU — Record-Keeping Without Writing

- › Knotted cords of different colors, materials, and knot types used to record data
- › Recorded: census data, tribute amounts, calendars, historical records, and possibly narrative information
- › Operated by specialist administrators called **quipucamayocs**
- › **AP significance:** Proves that complex governance is possible WITHOUT a writing system; challenges the assumption that literacy = sophistication

THE INCA ROAD NETWORK

- › ~25,000 miles of road connecting the empire (longer than the Roman road network)
- › Two main roads: coastal road and Andean road; linked by lateral connections
- › No wheeled vehicles — everything moved by foot and llama caravan
- › **Chasqui** (relay runners) carried messages and small goods at speeds of up to 150 miles/day
- › Roads enabled: rapid military deployment, tribute collection, state communication, and redistribution of food (state storehouses called qollqas lined the roads)

RELIGION AND POLITICAL LEGITIMACY

- › Inca emperor (Sapa Inca) was believed to be a direct descendant of **Inti** (the Sun God)
- › Dead emperors were mummified and treated as living rulers — consulted for decisions, attended feasts
- › **Machu Picchu** (built c. 1450s): Royal retreat and religious center; astronomical alignments in construction
- › Temple of the Sun (Coricancha) in Cusco: Most sacred shrine; walls lined with gold

SUMMARY — Write the main idea of this page in your own words:

Inca Empire (Tawantinsuyu) = largest pre-Columbian empire; expanded rapidly under **Pachacuti** (1438). Taxed through **mit'a** (labor service, not goods). Governed without writing using **quipu** (knotted cords). **Road network** (~25,000 miles) enabled military and administrative control. Emperor = son of the Sun God (Inti). Key AP comparison: mit'a (labor tax) vs. Aztec tribute (goods tax) vs. European feudal obligations.

CUES & AP QUESTIONS

NOTES

Cahokia:

Where? When? How large? What does it reveal?

What were the Mississippian peoples?

How did Cahokia compare to contemporary European cities?

AP EXAM TIP

Cahokia appears in AP stimulus questions as evidence that North America had large, complex, urban societies **BEFORE** European contact. Always use it to counter the myth of North America as 'wilderness' before 1492.

Name 2 other North American cultures from this period.

Why did Cahokia decline?

COMMON MISTAKE

North America was **NOT** empty or uncivilized before European contact. Cahokia (pop. ~20,000 at peak) was larger than London in 1100 CE. Hundreds of distinct cultures, languages, and political forms existed across the continent.

CAHOKIA — North America's Largest Pre-Contact City

- › Located near modern St. Louis, Missouri; at the confluence of the Missouri and Mississippi Rivers
- › Peak population: ~10,000–20,000 (c. 1050–1150 CE) — larger than contemporary London
- › Center of the Mississippian culture — a network of chiefdoms across the Mississippi River valley
- › **Monks Mound:** Massive flat-topped earthen pyramid — the largest pre-Columbian structure north of Mexico; used for elite ceremonies and possibly the ruler's residence
- › Woodhenge: Circular arrangement of wooden posts used for astronomical observation (calendar)

MISSISSIPPIAN CULTURE (c. 800–1600 CE)

- › Agricultural society based on maize cultivation (maize adopted from Mesoamerica via trade)
- › Organized into chiefdoms — hierarchical societies led by a chief with religious and political authority
- › Long-distance trade network: copper from Great Lakes, shells from Gulf Coast, obsidian from Rocky Mountains
- › Mound-building across the region — flat-topped mounds for temples/elite residences, conical mounds for burials

WHY CAHOKIA DECLINED (c. 1200–1350)

- › Environmental degradation: deforestation, soil exhaustion from intensive maize agriculture
- › Possible drought/climate change: Medieval Warm Period ended; Little Ice Age began
- › Political instability: large chiefdoms are difficult to maintain without writing/bureaucracy
- › Population dispersed to smaller settlements — no single catastrophic collapse
- › **AP significance:** Shows that even advanced North American societies faced environmental limits — a theme connecting to CCOT

OTHER NORTH AMERICAN CULTURES

- › **Ancestral Puebloans (Anasazi):** Southwest (modern Arizona/New Mexico/Colorado); multi-story stone/adobe villages (pueblos); Chaco Canyon as a regional center; declined c. 1300 due to drought
- › **Haudenosaunee (Iroquois Confederacy):** Northeast; five nations united in a political confederation with a constitution — remarkable early example of democratic governance
- › **Pacific Northwest coastal peoples:** Dense populations supported by salmon; sophisticated art and trade; potlatch ceremonies for redistribution of wealth

WHAT NORTH AMERICAN COMPLEXITY SHOWS FOR AP

The diversity of North American societies — from urban Cahokia to the Ancestral Puebloans' drought-adaptation to the Haudenosaunee political confederation — demonstrates that complex social organization took many different forms across the Americas, none dependent on Old World contact.

SUMMARY — Write the main idea of this page in your own words:

Cahokia (peak c. 1050–1150) = North America's largest pre-contact city; Monks Mound rivals Old World monuments. **Mississippian culture** = maize-based chiefdoms with long-distance trade networks. Cahokia declined c. 1200–1350 due to environmental stress. Other North American complexity: **Ancestral Puebloans** (stone architecture, drought adaptation) and **Haudenosaunee Confederacy** (democratic political union). All independently developed, no Old World contact.

CUES & AP QUESTIONS

NOTES

What role did religion play in Aztec political legitimacy?

Huitzilopochtli

Who? What was his significance?

How did Inca religion reinforce the emperor's authority?

AP EXAM TIP

Religion in the Americas served the **SAME** political functions as religion in the Old World: legitimizing rulers, unifying populations, and justifying extraction of labor and tribute. Use this comparison in thematic essays on governance.

What is an altepetl? (Aztec city-state)

COMMON MISTAKE

Do NOT present Aztec human sacrifice as uniquely barbaric without context. Many world cultures practiced ritual killing. Evaluate it within the Aztec cosmological framework: without human blood, the sun would stop. This is a religious belief, not evidence of a 'less civilized' society.

How did Machu Picchu function as a religious site?

AZTEC COSMOLOGY AND POLITICAL RELIGION

- › Aztec believed the world had been created and destroyed four times; they lived in the Fifth Sun
- › The sun required human blood (sacrifice) to continue rising each day — a cosmic obligation
- › **Huitzilopochtli** (sun and war god) demanded sacrifice; **Tlaloc** (rain god) demanded children's tears for rain
- › The emperor was the representative of the gods on earth — his military success = divine favor
- › **Templo Mayor** (Great Temple) at Tenochtitlan: Twin pyramids — one for Huitzilopochtli, one for Tlaloc; center of the Aztec cosmos
- › Flower Wars (xochiyaoyotl): Ritualized battles fought specifically to capture prisoners for sacrifice, not to kill

INCA COSMOLOGY AND POLITICAL RELIGION

- › **Sapa Inca** (emperor) = son of **Inti** (the Sun God) — divine kingship similar to Egyptian pharaohs and Khmer devaraja
- › **Ancestor veneration**: Mummified emperors were kept and treated as living — consulted for decisions, brought to public feasts, owned property
- › **Huacas**: Sacred places throughout the empire (mountains, springs, boulders) connected by invisible lines (ceques) radiating from Cusco — made the entire landscape sacred
- › **Machu Picchu**: Built c. 1450; royal estate and religious center; astronomical alignments allow sun to shine directly into the Intihuatana (sun dial) at solstices
- › **Sacrifices**: Capacocha — child sacrifice at major state events; far less frequent than Aztec sacrifice

MAYA WRITING AND CALENDAR (CONTEXT)

Though the Classic Maya (900 CE) predate this chapter, Maya writing (hieroglyphics) and the Long Count calendar are relevant context. By 1200, Maya city-states still existed but were decentralized. Maya literacy and astronomical knowledge demonstrate that writing systems developed independently in the Americas — challenging any claim that literacy required Old World contact.

RELIGION AS POLITICAL LEGITIMACY — CROSS-CULTURAL PATTERN

- › **Aztec emperor**: Representative of sun god; military success = divine favor
- › **Inca Sapa Inca**: Son of Inti; divine kingship
- › **Chinese emperor**: Mandate of Heaven
- › **European king**: Divine right of kings; papal coronation
- › **Pattern**: All major states in Unit 1 used religion to legitimize political authority. This is a universal human pattern, not unique to any one culture.

AP TIP: The parallel between Aztec/Inca divine kingship and the Chinese Mandate of Heaven, Egyptian pharaohs, and Khmer devaraja is a high-value comparison for LEQ and DBQ complexity points.

SUMMARY — Write the main idea of this page in your own words:

Aztec cosmology: the sun required **human sacrifice** to continue rising; the emperor was divine representative; Templo Mayor at the cosmos center. Inca cosmology: **Sapa Inca = son of Inti**; mummified emperors treated as living; entire landscape made sacred (huacas). Both used religion to legitimize political authority — parallel to Chinese Mandate of Heaven, Khmer devaraja, and European divine right. Religion as legitimacy = a universal state-building tool.

CUES & AP QUESTIONS

NOTES

How was Aztec society stratified?

What was the role of women in Aztec society?

How did Inca social structure differ from Aztec?

AP EXAM TIP

For AP social structure essays, compare Americas to Old World: both Aztec and Inca had hereditary nobility, warrior classes, priests, and commoners — similar to feudal Europe and China. What's distinctive: both used religion (not just economic power) as the primary basis for elite status.

What is a pochteca? Why are they significant for AP?

COMMON MISTAKE

Women's roles in Mesoamerican and Andean societies were not uniform. In the Inca Empire, the *akllakuna* ('chosen women') who wove textiles for the state held a privileged position. Gender roles were complex, not simply oppressive.

How did slavery function in the Americas?

AZTEC SOCIAL HIERARCHY

- › **Nobility (pipiltin):** Hereditary elite; held government and military offices; exempt from tribute; owned land
- › **Warriors:** Social mobility possible through military achievement — commoners could rise to elite status by capturing enemies in battle
- › **Priests:** Maintained temples, performed sacrifices, kept calendars; educated elite
- › **Merchants (pochteca):** Long-distance traders who also served as spies for the empire; paradoxically low in formal hierarchy but wealthy and influential
- › **Commoners (macehualtin):** Paid tribute, farmed, provided mit'a-like labor for public projects
- › **Enslaved people (tlacotin):** Could be sold, but their children were free — not hereditary slavery

POCHTECA — Aztec Long-Distance Merchants

A specialized, hereditary merchant class who traveled far beyond Aztec territory to trade luxury goods. They maintained their own deity (Yacatecuhtli), courts, and neighborhoods. **AP significance:** Shows that Aztec had sophisticated long-distance commercial networks, and that merchant identity could be distinct from the tribute-based political economy.

INCA SOCIAL STRUCTURE

- › **Sapa Inca:** Divine emperor at apex; owned all land theoretically
- › **Nobility (orejones):** Relatives of the Sapa Inca; administrative officials
- › **Curacas:** Local rulers of conquered peoples who collaborated with Inca administration — kept in power in exchange for loyalty and tribute collection
- › **Commoners:** Owed mit'a labor; received food and tools from state storehouses in return
- › **Akllakuna ('chosen women'):** Selected girls trained at state institutions to weave, brew chicha, and serve in temples or as wives of nobles — a privileged but controlled role

GENDER ROLES IN THE AMERICAS

- › **Aztec:** Complementary gender roles — men in warfare/agriculture, women in weaving/childrearing. Childbirth compared to warfare in ritual status. Elite women had religious roles. Polygamy among nobility.
- › **Inca:** State recruited women (akllakuna) for textile production and ritual service — state-managed gender labor. Ayllu (community) was organized around kinship, with both male and female labor obligations to the state.
- › **Overall:** Patriarchal but with specific honored roles for women in both religious and productive spheres

SLAVERY IN THE AMERICAS

Both Aztec and Inca had forms of enslaved labor, but not the hereditary chattel slavery that would characterize the Atlantic slave trade. Aztec tlacotin (enslaved) could earn freedom; their children were born free. Prisoners of war were sacrificed rather than enslaved long-term. This is a significant structural difference from Old World slavery.

SUMMARY — Write the main idea of this page in your own words:

Aztec social hierarchy: nobles, warriors (social mobility via battle), priests, **pochteca** (long-distance merchants), commoners, enslaved. **Military achievement = path to social mobility** (rare in most Old World contexts). Inca: Sapa Inca at apex; mit'a labor; akllakuna (chosen women) as state-managed labor. Both patriarchal with specific honored roles for women. Slavery existed but was NOT hereditary chattel slavery — children were born free.

CUES & AP QUESTIONS	NOTES
CCOT Framework: <i>What changed in the Americas 1200–1450? What stayed the same?</i> <i>Top 3 AP essay prompts for Ch. 5:</i> <i>Key comparisons for Ch. 5 essays:</i> AP EXAM TIP The #1 Ch. 5 AP trap: using Old World events (Mongols, Black Death, Islam) to explain the Americas. The Americas were isolated. Any essay that connects them to the Old World before 1492 is historically inaccurate. COMMON MISTAKES (1) Saying Americas were 'primitive' — Tenochtitlan was larger than London. (2) Using Old World events to explain Americas. (3) Confusing Aztec (Mexico) with Inca (Peru). (4) Forgetting Cahokia when discussing North America. <i>Terms to define in essays:</i>	CCOT FRAMEWORK FOR CHAPTER 5 › CONTINUITIES: Maize agriculture as foundation of all major Mesoamerican/North American civilizations Religious legitimization of political authority Tribute/labor extraction as state funding mechanism Long-distance trade within the Americas › CHANGES: Aztec Empire rapidly expands via Triple Alliance (1428) Inca Empire expands under Pachacuti (1438) Cahokia declines c. 1200–1350 Mississippian culture spreads maize agriculture further north › COMPLEXITY: Americas developed sophisticated state-building, monumental architecture, and trade networks entirely independently — evidence against Eurocentric assumptions about complexity TOP AP ESSAY PROMPTS › 1. LEQ: 'Compare state-building in the Americas to state-building in ONE other region 1200–1450.' → Compare Aztec tribute system to Chinese tribute system, OR Inca mit'a to Egyptian corvée labor, OR Aztec divine kingship to Khmer devaraja › 2. SAQ: 'Explain ONE similarity and ONE difference between the Aztec and Inca empires.' → Similarity: both used religion to legitimize authority; Difference: Aztec used goods tribute, Inca used mit'a labor tax › 3. LEQ: 'Analyze the role of religion in the political systems of TWO civilizations in Unit 1.' → Use Aztec (human sacrifice for sun) + ONE other (Chinese Mandate of Heaven, or Khmer devaraja) KEY AP-READY COMPARISONS › Aztec tribute vs. Chinese tribute system: Both extractive; Chinese more diplomatic/voluntary; Aztec more military/coercive › Inca mit'a vs. European serfdom: Both labor obligations to a state/lord; mit'a = temporary state service; serfdom = permanent hereditary obligation › Aztec/Inca divine kingship vs. Khmer devaraja / Chinese Mandate of Heaven: All use religion to legitimize political authority — a universal state-building tool › Inca quipu vs. writing systems: Both are administrative record-keeping — proves complexity does not require alphabetic writing › Cahokia vs. European feudal towns: Cahokia was larger than many European towns — challenges assumptions about pre-contact North America KEY TERMS TO DEFINE Aztec / Mexica Triple Alliance Tenochtitlan Tribute system Mit'a Quipu Sapa Inca Tawantinsuyu Pachacuti Chinampas Pochteca Akllakuna Cahokia Mississippian Ancestral Puebloans Isolation Columbian Exchange (Unit 2 preview) AP TIP: End any Americas essay with a forward connection — the Americas' isolation meant their populations had no immunity to Old World diseases, which is WHY the Columbian Exchange (Unit 3) was so catastrophic. This forward connection earns complexity points.
SUMMARY — Write the main idea of this page in your own words:	

Ch. 5 AP mastery: (1) **Americas = isolation**; never use Old World events to explain Aztec/Inca; (2) **Tenochtitlan** and **Machu Picchu** = your evidence for monumental achievement; (3) **Mit'a vs. tribute** = the key Aztec/Inca distinction; (4) **Quipu** = governance without writing; (5) **Cahokia** = North American complexity before contact. Best forward connection: isolation → no disease immunity → Columbian Exchange catastrophe.